
CACR Depot Access Road — Climate, Ecological and Flood Risk Concerns Regarding Option 7

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Cc: info@transport.gov.ie

Sun, Jun 7, 2026 at 7:01 PM

Dear Mr O'Ciaruain,

I am writing to you as a directly affected resident near Ballyrichard, Carrigtwohill, Co. Cork, regarding Irish Rail's selection of Option 7 as the preferred depot access road for the Cork Area Commuter Rail (CACR) maintenance facility. This proposal was developed by Roughan & O'Donovan Consulting Engineers on behalf of Irish Rail and has been met with overwhelming public opposition from East Cork. I am raising this with your division specifically because I believe the selection raises serious concerns under the headings of embodied carbon, ecological integrity, climate resilience, and the effective use of public infrastructure funding.

Construction carbon and land use

Option 7 requires the offline construction of over 1km of new road through active agricultural land, which explicitly states that this "will require construction materials and subsequent embodied carbon." Other lower-impact alternatives exist, reusing infrastructure that is already in place, avoiding new incursion into farmland, and reducing the destruction of fully grown oak, ash and other trees. Hedgerows are recognised carbon sinks and biodiversity corridors; their unnecessary removal runs counter to Ireland's land use and climate commitments.

Operational emissions and routing efficiency

Option 7 routes depot traffic in a manner that requires vehicles to travel through or around Midleton and back out towards Carrigtwohill, an inefficient circuit that adds road kilometres and emissions for every operational journey. The cumulative difference in vehicle kilometres over the depot's lifetime is material.

Flood risk — assessed as neutral, contradicted by evidence

Irish Rail's flawed Option Selection Report scores Option 7 as Neutral on flood risk and states: "No indication of Fluvial, Coastal, Groundwater or Pluvial sources of flooding." Residents hold photographic evidence — available at (<https://no2option7.org/technical-evidence.html>) — showing the land along the proposed Option 7 route already under standing floodwater during periods of heavy rainfall, and the Castle Rock Avenue culvert already at or beyond capacity. This was before the Waterrock Developments recent directing of flood water to this same exact location. This evidence directly contradicts the Neutral rating. Under projected climate conditions, with increased rainfall intensity, a route that demonstrably floods under existing conditions represents a serious infrastructure risk. No detailed flood risk assessment or climate resilience assessment has been carried out for this route.

Ecological designations

Independent ecological survey work carried out at the adjacent Water-Rock site (Woodrow APEM, March 2026) confirmed the presence of five Annex IV bat species using hedgerows along the Option 7 corridor as commuting routes, two BoCCI Red-listed bird species (Yellowhammer and Snipe) breeding and wintering in the same agricultural land, and the hydrological link to the Great Island Channel SAC referenced above. None of these findings have been assessed in the context of the Option 7 route selection. The cumulative impacts of this project were also omitted from the ecological report's own cumulative effects table — a material gap that an EIA-level assessment would be expected to address.

Please help

I respectfully ask that the Department, in its oversight role, request that Irish Rail carry out a comparative carbon and climate resilience assessment across the shortlisted options before any route is confirmed — and that the concerns raised here be brought to Irish Rail's board. The public consultation closes on 19 June 2026. Residents had one month from getting access to maps for the first time to the deadline for closing the consultation so please do not delay.

Full technical grounds, source document references, and further detail are available at <https://no2option7.org/technical-evidence.html>.

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss this further.

Yours sincerely,
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